

off involves getting some sort of windfall in the future or dying with his debt—much like our friends with the high student loans from earlier chapters. Student debt is trending in our national conversation, but medical debt affects everyone, even those who don't have the privilege of attending college or graduate school.

Like student debt, though, Scott said people still believe his medical debt is his fault, that he's some sort of lazy person living off the state or, worse, that he gave himself cancer with poor habits. (Scott was running marathons when he was diagnosed, not that he should have to defend himself.)

Scott may have had insurance, but not all cancer-related needs are covered by insurance. For example, the biggest side effect of Scott's chemo treatments was the loss of his teeth, but dental work to fix them wasn't covered.

There was one incident where one of his teeth needed to be removed and the dentist told Scott, "We don't have time to do the implant and replacement," because he wouldn't heal in time for his chemo appointment. He could either delay chemo and have the tooth worked on and thus saved, or have the tooth pulled out completely and do the chemo. Not a great set of choices there. That's when he learned that a lot of the cosmetic surgery we need on our teeth isn't covered by insurance. "Because you don't need teeth to survive," he said. I would argue you do need teeth to survive, but apparently insurance companies think you can live the rest of your life drinking through a straw. "A lot of people just go without teeth," he said. Most of Scott's teeth are now fake and expensive.

Later in his treatments, he faced a scarier medical choose-your-own-adventure. At one point during chemo, his white blood cell count dropped low, and his body was increasingly susceptible to potentially fatal disease or infection. A decision needed to be made: Should Scott take a pause from chemo to get his white blood cell count back up, even though that would leave him vulnerable to more tumor growth? It seemed like a no-win until his doctor mentioned The Shot.

The shot, Neulasta, would increase his white blood cell count without Scott having to go off chemo. When you google Neulasta, comment threads of cancer patients bemoan the cost of it as anywhere from \$6,000 to \$9,000. Scott said he remembers his costing \$12,000. "Your doctor could make the case for you to have this shot, which my doctor of course did, but it's up to the insurance